"My restaurant has a new look thanks to Mundhe sahab and FDA officials who pointed to shortcomings."

The FDA's crackdown has also had consequences beyond individual eateries. Vikram Pachpute, BJP MLA from Shrigonda in Ahilyanagar, says the ban on analogue paneer has led to the price of cows' milk rising from Rs 20-24 per litre in April-May 2024 to Rs 40-42 now. Pachpute had first raised the issue of analogue paneer in the assembly in 2025, leading to the state government announcing a crackdown on synthetic paneer.

Feedback suggests that the FDA's inspections have led to improved standards, with consumers reporting changes in the taste and colour of products. Greater awareness has also prompted a surge in complaints: the FDA has received 16,000 in the past three months, underscoring the enormous scale of its task. A senior FDA official says its ambit covers around 1.25 million registered licences across Maharashtra, but it has only about 350 food safety officials. In Mumbai, which has around 100,000 licensees, the FDA has only 45 officers.

THE MAKING OF MUNDHE

Born in June 1975 in Tadsonna, Beed district, in the rain-shadow Marathwada region, Mundhe grew up working in the family's fields and could not afford even a pair of chappals. His life took a turn when his brother Ashok, 11 years his senior, took him to Aurangabad (now Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar) for his education. But life there remained a struggle. In his early days in the city, Mundhe often subsisted on bananas and *farsan* to stave off hunger. Ashok, who went on to become a civil servant, ensured that his younger brother could prepare for the public service commission examinations.

From his first posting as a trainee in Solapur in 2005, Mundhe hit the ground running, raiding a dance bar owned by a minister. During an anti-encroachment drive, he first brought down the illegal compound wall of the local tehsil office before turning the hammer on others. As assistant collector at Degloor in Nanded in 2007, he took on the sand mafia and was threatened by alleged Naxals.

Despite his clean image, willingness to stand up to the powers that be and his forthright nature—which some may interpret as arrogance—Mundhe's career has not been without controversy. As secretary in the Divyang Kalyan department (August 2025-May 2026), he was reported to have spent an astronomical Rs 65-70 lakh on refurbishing his official flat on Malabar Hill. It was during this tenure that he led a crackdown on fake disability certificates. As municipal commissioner of Navi Mumbai (May 2016-March 2017), Mundhe was accused of ill-treating elected representatives. In December 2025, BJP MLA Krishna Khopde of Nagpur claimed Mundhe's supporters had threatened him after he accused Mundhe of corruption.

With 25 transfers in 21 years of service, Mundhe's career has been a chequered one. As he said at a *Business Today* conclave, the transfers took a toll on his family, including his son, who had to change schools every year until the family moved to Mumbai in 2019.



"We expect the FDA to act in a judicious manner by issuing an improvement notice, and then suspend the licence if the FBO continues to err"

— NIRANJAN SHETTY
Chairman, Legal Cell, Indian Hotel & Restaurant Association

A former batchmate sees Mundhe's biggest achievement as the fact that "he has not changed his colours after spending two decades in service". But he also offers a note of caution: "Mundhe often loses sight of the fact that rules exist for people, and not the other way round." Meanwhile, the FDA campaign has won Mundhe a cult following. Shafi Pathan, author of his Marathi biography, *Tukaram*, released in late July, claims that around 100,000 copies had been pre-booked. And his Instagram following has crossed 3.8 million.

THE BACKLASH

Mundhe's enforcement blitzkrieg has also come under judicial scrutiny. "Do you feel you are a lord, and you can do anything?" the HC said, questioning the FDA over its move on August 21 to suspend the licences of five restaurants operating on the MCA premises. The HC had earlier directed the FDA to pay Rs 5 lakh to a Pune-based sweet shop whose licence remained suspended despite its compliance with the norms. It had also questioned the FDA's drastic measures, saying it was trying to "kill a mosquito with a sword".

A former FDA commissioner warns that such sweeping actions could lead to a return of the dreaded 'Inspector Raj'. Regulators, the former commissioner says, need to take stakeholders into confidence and sensitise them before taking action. Niranjan Shetty, chairman of the legal cell of the Indian Hotel & Restaurant Association, says they expect the FDA to "act in a judicious manner", by first issuing an improvement notice to an establishment and then suspending the licence if the FBO continues to err. Shetty points out that infestations of cockroaches and rodents in kitchens could also be blamed on poor management of drainage and solid waste by civic bodies.

For the industry, the bigger concern, however, lies beyond the licensed sector. Ganesh Shetty, president, Pune Restaurant and Hoteliers' Association, admits that while some establishments did not maintain hygienic standards, it was wrong to penalise them for shortfalls in the quality of raw materials such as paneer, which are procured from vendors. "There are several unlicensed operators who operate from their homes and online...cloud kitchens are proliferating. They show a certain registered address with a few cooking implements as a front, but actually cook the bulk of their food in slums and in unhygienic conditions," says Shetty. "There is no control on them."

There are murmurs in the food industry that, despite Mundhe's intentions, lower-level officials may still be involved in rent-seeking. Mundhe, however, remains unfazed. "If there is no role left for regulators, I will be the happiest person," he says, stressing the need for mass awareness. ■